

BBC 6 Minute English Listening Practice

How Reading Shapes Your Brain

Name: _____

Class: _____

Score: _____ / 20

No.	Sentence
1	Many people assume reading develops in the same way as speaking because it feels _____.
2	One mistaken assumption is that reading must be natural because it is a form of _____.
3	At birth, the brain already supports seeing and sound production through the _____.
4	However, babies do not already have the brain _____ needed for reading.
5	Evolution has not given humans a _____.
6	To read, the brain borrows areas used for vision, _____, language, attention and emotion.
7	Reading activates all _____ of the cortex.
8	Developing this ability can alter brain activity, structure and _____.
9	Reading Chinese symbols activates different brain areas from reading an _____.
10	Chinese characters place stronger demands on visual memory and _____.

11 **What point does Maryanne Wolf make about reading?**

- A It develops automatically once children can speak.
- B It is easier than spoken language for most people.
- C It is not an ability that humans are naturally born to do.
- D It uses no connection with language.

12 **What do babies already have brain networks for?**

- A Seeing and producing sounds.
- B Reading printed words fluently.
- C Understanding every language they hear.
- D Connecting symbols with abstract ideas.

Answers written in the margins will not be marked.

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- 13 **Why does the brain need to use existing systems when learning to read?**
- A Reading requires only visual memory.
 - B The cortex cannot change after childhood.
 - C Spoken language prevents a reading network from forming.
 - D There has not been enough evolutionary time for a separate reading brain.
- 14 **Which group of brain functions is mentioned as being recruited for reading?**
- A Smell, balance, memory and movement.
 - B Vision, sound processing, language and attention.
 - C Hunger, emotion, sleep and breathing.
 - D Pain response, touch, taste and imagination.
- 15 **How does Rebecca Gottlieb characterise reading overall?**
- A A narrow skill handled by one small brain area.
 - B A mainly mechanical process unrelated to identity.
 - C A habit that changes only vocabulary knowledge.
 - D A whole-brain process that can reshape who we are.
- 16 **What is one result of learning to read, according to the explanation?**
- A It changes brain structure compared with not learning to read.
 - B It removes the need for attention and language systems.
 - C It makes all readers use identical brain circuits.
 - D It prevents later changes in brain connectivity.
- 17 **What makes Chinese characters different from alphabetic writing in this discussion?**
- A They represent only sounds and never ideas.
 - B They are easier for stroke patients to read.
 - C They use symbols rather than alphabet letters.
 - D They do not require visual processing.
- 18 **What does the bilingual stroke case suggest?**
- A Chinese and English must be stored in exactly the same brain areas.
 - B Different writing systems can rely on different brain circuits.
 - C A stroke normally improves alphabet reading.
 - D People who read Chinese cannot read English after brain injury.

- 19 **Why does Maryanne Wolf mention the "requirements of Chinese"?**
- A To argue that Chinese is less detailed than English.
 - B To claim that alphabet systems use no memory.
 - C To show that Chinese reading damages the circuit.
 - D To explain why Chinese reading develops more visual memory and processing.
- 20 **What broader conclusion is supported by the final explanation of Chinese symbols?**
- A The visual form of a writing system can shape brain development.
 - B Detailed characters make reading impossible for bilingual people.
 - C Alphabetic reading always produces stronger visual areas.
 - D Brain circuits are fixed and unaffected by literacy.